

Giving oranges during their New Year season is a festive ritual of the Chinese. They are usually given in pairs as a symbol of friendship.

I said nothing.

Pongo looked everywhere for the oranges. He looked in my pockets. He looked in my apron. But he didn't find one orange.

Finally, Pongo understood what had happened. But it was very difficult to believe.

'Seventeen oranges!', he said. 'Seventeen big oranges! How did you eat them all?'

I said nothing. Pongo was not able to send me to prison. There was no evidence.

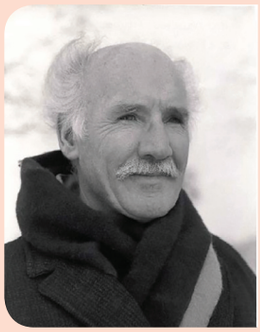
Pongo became angry and shouted at me. But I didn't say a word. In the end, he had to let me go.

I told Clem Jones about the seventeen oranges.

'Pongo locked you in that cabin for half an hour,' said Clem. 'He had no right to do that.'

Perhaps Clem was right. I don't know. I didn't have time to think about it. I had eaten seventeen large oranges - peels, pips and all. I felt very sick for a week and those oranges kept working away in my stomach.

About the Author



William John Francis Naughton, known as Bill Naughton (1910-1992) was an Irish-born British playwright and author. He worked as a weaver, coal-bagger and lorry-driver before he started writing. His preferred environment was working class society, which is reflected in much of his work. He wrote many novels, short stories, plays and children's books. He is best known for the play *Alfie.* His 1977, children's novel *My Pal Spadger* is an account of his childhood in 1920s Bolton.

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Glossary

docks (n) - an enclosed area of water in a port for the loading, unloading and repair of ships

apron (n) - a protective garment worn over the front of one's clothes and tied at the back

9th English Unit 4 PR PO Supple Pages 088-116.indd 92 28-11-2022 17:27:18